Center for Bridge Education Newsletter - Spring 2024

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Street Taco Going Strong



Every Saturday afternoon we meet up casually at **Street Taco** (980 16th St, San Francisco, CA 94107) where kids and adult mentors come to play hands of bridge and eat chips and guacamole (and sometimes burritos and tacos, hence the name). Our Street Taco program has been up and running every Saturday for a full year. This is the first time CBE has been running a truly weekly meetup since pre-pandemic when we would meet every Saturday at the hospital. The kids really look forward to coming every week and almost always play beyond the allotted 3 hours we set aside. We even saw some students that used to come pre-pandemic return to the game.

Thanks to all the volunteers that graciously donate their time to show up and mentor the kids. Mentors include: William Zhu, Chris Chen, Dan Kroll, Anant Rathi, Amber Lin, Kevin Rosenberg, John and Allison Kranyak, and Sylvia Shi.

Bridge and a Splash of Guacamole



By Jayson Lee

Street Taco is more than just a Saturday event; it's a fun gathering of friends where experienced mentors teach young kids in San Francisco the fundamentals of bridge over chips and guacamole. Under the guidance of the mentors - Will, Anant, Dan, and Chris - we learn new conventions and how to play bridge more strategically. The mentors observe our play, offering constructive feedback after every hand. Each session is highlighted on my calendar, as it is always something to look forward to. It is always filled with excitement, fun, and enthusiasm as all the kids and mentors bring the fun to the table.

A few weeks ago, Dan made a specific hand to teach us a play concept. This concept was to pitch a loser to a loser to set up a winner. This is important because you gain a trick for free, and it always works! I played the king of hearts from the dummy and pitched my losing club. This set up my queen of hearts and I also got rid of my club which helped me make my four spade contract. Some other concepts that they have taught us are: 2-way new minor forcing, a bidding convention that promises a game forcing hand or an invitational hand; gamble 3NT, a daring bid that is the definition of luck as the bid requires a very special hand; and support doubles, a double that fine-tunes the amount of a suit you have.

I encourage others to join us at Street Taco, as I have learned so many new things. Our mentors have built a community where every new learned convention is celebrated, where every misstep is seen as an opportunity to grow, and where every game is a fresh place to start. I'm so grateful for our mentors and all of the time that they have dedicated to teaching us one Saturday at a time.

CBE Kids at Quicktricks



December 18, 2023 - Two CBE teams vie for first place in the final round of the QuickTricks team game

In addition to our weekly Saturday Street Taco event, we encourage the kids to compete on the last Monday of each month at the premier face-to-face bridge club in town, QuickTricks, which holds weekly games in the Castro (100 Diamond St.). We've always encouraged our kids to play in the “last Monday” Quicktricks team games to get more exposure to topnotch competition. In the beginning our kids hoped to place at a respectable position. Now the kids expect to win every time they enter. In December 2023 CBE fielded two teams, each a mix of kids and mentors, that won every match prior to meeting in the final match. The final round ended in a draw; a fitting end that left both teams undefeated.

The kids have enjoyed going to “Gyro Xpress” after the games (time permitting) and discussing the hands with their CBE mentors, Board members William Zhu, Chris Chen, Anant Rathi and Dan Kroll, along with occasional special guest mentors who have included world class experts Amber Lin, Kevin Rosenberg, John Kranyak and Allison Kranyak!



Gyro Express, our go-to spot after QuickTricks

CBE SiVY Summer Tournament

CBE and SiVY (another Bay Area bridge non-profit) are working together to connect the SF and South Bay bridge playing regions. This summer we plan to host a CBE vs SiVY team game as a warmup event to the Youth NABC.

Summer Youth NABC in Toronto - Training Starts Now

The Youth North American Bridge Championship (YNABC) will be in Toronto, Canada, in mid-July 2024. As we have done in the past, CBE plans to partially subsidize the travel and hotel expenses for kids who have been attending our programs and show a willingness to train for and attend the YNABC. As discussed in our last newsletter in the Summer of 2023, the CBE youths triumphed in multiple events in last summer's YNABC, and we expect them to demonstrate their bridge prowess yet again this summer!

Our Mission

The Center for Bridge Education has been promoting the game of Bridge in the San Francisco Bay Area since 2007. We have dedicated mentors who volunteer their time to teach bridge to youths, whether in person, online, and/or by encouraging and assisting high school bridge clubs. One of our current programs is hosting the “Street Taco Saturday” weekly meetup where kids from all over the Bay Area come to learn and play bridge, eat tacos, and have fun. Another is fostering and organizing the youths’ attendance each week at QuickTricks, a preeminent SF bridge club, and discussing the hands with them afterwards. Both programs help prepare the kids for the Youth NABC at the ACBL summer nationals and stimulate them to continue their bridge education in other ways, including by starting or joining bridge clubs at their high schools and colleges, as some of our youths have gone on to do.

CBE Thanks You

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